

bet that I put in the Gillette order on the spot. We sold 2,500 shares of Angstrom for \$4,289.75, a loss of \$781.82, and invested nearly all of it in 53 shares of Gillette at 79¼. I remembered to ask about Gillette's P/E ratio, and Ms. Garrett said it was 14. She guessed that Gillette's 14 was a lot lower than Angstrom's P/E, and I felt confident Mr. Frank would have approved of the switch.

As soon as I'd bought the stock, I called Ms. Hall. Getting through to the analyst in person was easier than I expected. The main switchboard operator at Prudential-Bache connected me right to her line and she answered her own phone. I introduced myself as a writer and a Prudential-Bache client who'd taken a major position in one of her stocks, and who wanted to make sure he'd done the right thing. She kindly agreed to let me visit her in her office.

The part about the major position must have helped my cause, but I wouldn't have said it if I hadn't made a substantial commitment to the stock. If you're wondering how many shares you should own before pestering an analyst with a phone call, I'd suggest you follow Useful Tip Number 15:

Never bother an analyst if you own less than 53 shares

Prudential-Bache is housed in one of the many high-rises at the southern end of Manhattan along Water Street. Ms. Hall's office was located on an upper floor. The waiting room was full of what I'd call fine antique furniture, but I can never tell an original from a copy.

Nancy Hall came through the far door to greet me. She was tall and beautiful, and a thin, lime-colored scarf hung like a dorsal fin along her back. In any police lineup, I would have picked her for the fashion model and not the securities analyst, who I would have expected to be more stooped and shopworn.

She escorted me down a hallway and into her cubicle, which had a wonderful view of the harbor. Atop the usual clutter of pamphlets and magazines were samples of various shaving and